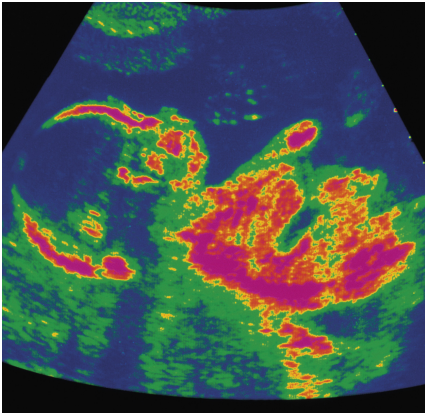




YOU ARE **23 WEEKS AND 5 DAYS**

114 days to go

YOUR BABY TODAY

In this color 2-D ultrasound scan the baby is lying face upward. It is now increasingly difficult to show the whole baby using this type of ultrasound because it only shows a thin slice at any one time. Here, only the upper part of the baby can be seen.

“Practicing yoga in pregnancy can be hugely beneficial, both physically and emotionally.”

Practicing yoga in pregnancy is safe and can help ease common discomforts. A recent study also found that pregnant women who practiced yoga had a decreased risk of developing pregnancy-induced high blood pressure and of going into preterm labor.

In addition to strengthening and toning muscles, yoga aims to bring about a greater awareness of your breathing. Learning to control your breathing is a great way to relax during pregnancy and an invaluable way to prepare to breathe through the contractions when you're in labor.

Standing poses in yoga focus on achieving core stability, thereby strengthening the abdominal and back muscles. This is beneficial during pregnancy when the additional weight you're carrying can affect your balance and cause unsteadiness. Calm sitting poses that concentrate on aligning your spine help you focus on steadying your breathing and centering yourself. If you feel unsteady doing yoga poses, you can simply lean against a wall.

Pilates is also a good exercise to do in pregnancy because it heightens your bodily awareness, giving you greater control of—and confidence in—your body. Pilates also incorporates [Kegel exercises](#).

Whatever classes you're doing, it's important to find an accredited instructor who is experienced in teaching pregnant women. There are now many specialized pregnancy yoga and Pilates classes.

ASK A DOCTOR

Why are hemorrhoids so common in pregnancy, and what can I do to relieve them?

Hemorrhoids are, like [varicose veins](#), dilated veins, but they occur around your anus. The weight of your baby pushes down on your back passage, restricting blood flow and causing the veins to dilate.

Hemorrhoids can be itchy and sore and may cause a throbbing sensation. The discomfort can be relieved with cold packs and creams containing lubricants to help the passage of stools,